the time when they were all wondering what to do with a discarded piece of Kani shawl. "She asked us to get five metres of crepe fabric and integrated the discarded piece into it to make a beautiful sari," says Mir.

Likewise, her interventions in *pherans*—the long traditional gown Kashmiris wear in winter—have produced stunning results. She introduced the paisley motif at the back of the garment, and got craftsmen to weave traditional colours in unusual combinations so that the final products became statement pieces. "Not only has the volume of our business increased but our craft is breathing again," says Mir, who was part of the six-member team from India that was invited to Oxford University in 2019 to share their experiences in different fields.

Ask her what drives her passion, and Soni says it's the feeling that she can perhaps play a part in bringing happiness into people's lives. "I am driven to spread happiness," she adds. "Art and creativity are in the blood of Kashmiris. What they lack is exposure. I am acting as that bridge."

The same impulse permeates Soni's paintings as well. A self-taught painter since childhood, she has done a series as a tribute to the 'last generation of artisans in Kashmir'. At 'The Autumn Art Exhibit' in Srinagar in November 2022, not only was her own art on display, but all were encouraged to participate. One painting in particular inspired much discussion. It showed a child in a cap on a papier mache-patterned prayer rug and rosary. "I used the papier mache background as a tribute to the artisans who are keeping the art alive against all odds," says Soni. "My work evoked a lot of curiosity among younger people. I am getting a lot of inquiries."

Alongside, Soni is trying to dispel the misconceptions and stereotypes around Kashmir through her works and promote 'peace' and 'positivity'. "There is a certain fear outside Kashmir that the place is not safe," she says. "But every bit of this place is inspiring. And that is the message I want to portray though my paintings." It's art with a heart. ■

Bit by bit, Sushanta Giri's mother wasted away, as the deadly liver ailment progressed. The family, who live in the remote Baikunthapur village in the Sundarbans in West Bengal, had no means to take her to the nearest subdivisional hospital at Joynagar, 49 km away, for treatment. Giri's eyes well up as he recalls those nights when his mother suffered acute pain, and how he frantically did the rounds of village quacks for some palliative. Giri's mother passed away the day he wrote the final paper of his school-leaving board exam. Back from the funeral, the 18-year-old resolved to help improve the living condition of the people who live in these coastal backwaters—the very margins both geographically and socio-economically—so that they could access the basic needs of life.

BAIKUNTHAPUR TARUN SANGHA
FOUNDED: 1983
The Sundarbans, West Bengal

For thousands of underprivileged villagers in the Sundarbans, life is not just about coping with poverty and the absence of healthcare, education and roads and communication, it is also fraught by a constant struggle with nature—cyclones, flash floods, farmland laid waste by saline water from the sea, and land erosion.

Giri embarked on a comprehensive plan of community development and self-sufficiency, so that villagers could send their children to schools and share in the possibilities of a rapidly digitising world.

The beginning, in 1983, was humble: a primary school run by the local Ekta Youth Club. Baikunthapur Tarun Sangha (BTS) began as a school for the underprivileged forced to discontinue their education due to acute poverty. "We had 25 students to begin with. Our main aim was to give basic education to local children and tie up with good schools for higher education. Education was highly subsidised—a tuition fee of Rs 5-7, and a free meal with milk," says Giri. Today, Baikunthapur Tarun Sangha is a reputed English-medium school till Class 8 with around 100 students. Earlier, teachers gave voluntary services; Giri is now able to pay them a monthly honorarium of Rs 2,000 because of aid and donors. BTS also has 500 former students—professionals like doctors, lawyers, teachers and nurses—who are doing their bit for their alma mater. "The primary school was a stepping stone for getting the FCRA (Foreign Contribution Regulation Act) registration in 1996," he says. But Giri has not stopped there. BTS's activities in healthcare, community development and employment generation cover 52 villages of 14 gram panchayats in seven blocks of the Sundarbans. The total number of beneficiaries is estimated to be 55,000.

Though the region is a Unesco-declared world heritage

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"When I see a young boy who could not afford to go to school become a doctor, lawyer, teacher or working in an MNC, I tear up in utter joy."

SUSHANTA GIRI, Founder, BTS